

Kallas pushes back

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna back with you.

In today's Playbook:

— The race to shape Ursula von der Leyen's State of the European Union is entering its final sprint.

— EU capitals are starting to show their hands in the budget negotiations.

— Faces in the crowd: Bjoern Seibert, Emmylou Harris, Jordan Bardella, Teresa Ribera, Séamus Boland, Pedro Sánchez, Anna Olsson Vrang, Mario Draghi, Thomas Byrne, Janja Jenc, António Costa, Victor Xiberras, Robert Golob, Camilla Saugstrup, Bárður á Steig Nielsen, Axel Voss, Conrad Hässler, Clara Cilius Rødgaard and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian discuss the red lines emerging in the EU's budget negotiations.

****A message from AMD: Open standards, interoperability, and supplier diversity will be the cornerstones of Europe's AI future. They drive innovation and choice, strengthen resilience, and provide opportunities to adopt and integrate novel technologies and new capabilities. Read how open technology stack drives choice across hardware, software and deployment models as the EU seeks to build sovereign AI capabilities.****

DRIVING THE DAY

INSIDE THE FIGHT TO SAVE THE EU'S DIPLOMATIC ARM: Kaja Kallas, the EU's chief diplomat, is leading a determined behind-the-scenes push to counter a Franco-German bid to overhaul her diplomatic service, officials and diplomats told Nicholas Vinocur in Ireland.

The fightback — which involves courting EU capitals and deploying her new secretary-general to lead the thinking on alternative reform plans — aims to head off drastic changes that could give Ursula von

der Leyen's European Commission more control over the work currently overseen by Kallas.

What to expect: The high representative is set to preside over a town hall today during which she'll introduce the EEAS's new secretary-general, Kaja Ollongren, who has been touring capitals to sound them out on the diplomatic service, three EU officials and one diplomat told Playbook and Jacopo Barigazzi. They were granted anonymity to discuss the sensitive maneuvering.

Look closer: The officials said they expected Ollongren to unveil plans for a "council of elders," or task force, that would lead reflections on EEAS reform separately from the Franco-German push. Belén Martínez Carbonell, Ollongren's predecessor as sec gen, has delayed her start as head of the EU's delegation to Mexico to advise Ollongren in this process, while senior EEAS official Charles Fries will also weigh in, the officials and diplomat said.

Flanking maneuver: Two EU diplomats said those plans would signal Kallas is keen to take control of the reform debate after EU foreign ministers gave the Franco-German proposals a muted reception during talks in Wicklow, Ireland, on Wednesday.

Step back: Talk of overhauling the EU's 15-year-old diplomatic service has gripped Brussels amid a flurry of leaked position papers and criticism that the EEAS is no longer fit for purpose in a world of raw power politics.

In Wicklow, Kallas agreed with the Franco-German aim of making EU foreign policy faster-moving and better able to protect the bloc's interests. But she said the blockages stem from rules requiring unanimous voting on foreign and security policy and the failure to properly apply EU treaties — not from the institutional setup.

"There was not support for concentrating everything in the Commission without having this [HRVP] role practically implemented," she told reporters after a debate with EU foreign ministers. Treaties and legal texts, she said, already in theory give her oversight of the Commission's external-facing policy units — exactly what the Franco-German paper proposes.

Kallas also suggested that such changes would not work if they reduced her autonomy and made her answer to "someone else" — in this case, the Commission president. "If I have somebody above me who is actually deciding, then it doesn't work that way," she said.

The bottom line: In the tug of war over the fate of the EEAS, it's Kallas's turn to pull.

BIG AND BREAKING

THE AfD'S BIG MOMENT: An Alternative for Germany lawmaker is pushing Germans to forget the Nazi past — and he could soon wield more power than any other far-right leader in the country's postwar history, James Angelos writes.

How the east was lost: An outright AfD victory in Saxony-Anhalt on Sunday would raise hard questions about how Angela Merkel, Friedrich Merz and other chancellors failed to stop parts of eastern Germany veering toward the far right, Anne McElvoy writes.

MOSCOW CAN'T SCARE US: Ursula von der Leyen and Mark Rutte vowed that suspected Russian attacks on Europe won't weaken support for Ukraine ... as a Russian drone struck a university building just 300 meters from the EU delegation in Kyiv.

Meanwhile: Moscow will close Russian branches of Germany's Goethe-Institut in response to Berlin blaming it for the drone incident at Leipzig Airport, Reuters reported overnight.

RIBERA'S BIG BILL: Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera wants Europe to start thinking bigger — and maybe spend bigger — to climate-proof itself.

CHATGPT'S LOOPHOLE: Brussels is treating ChatGPT as a search engine — leaving much of what people actually do with it outside the rules .

THE ROAD TO SOTEU

TIME'S RUNNING OUT TO IMPRESS VON DER LEYEN: The Commission website has a slightly ominous clock counting down to Ursula von der Leyen's State of the Union address. Playbook has a more useful countdown: the remaining opportunities to get something into her speech.

A tale of three meetings: There are three big moments left before von der Leyen takes to the podium on Sept. 16, according to seven officials and diplomats. First, all commissioners head to Tervuren, just outside Brussels, tomorrow for their traditional rentrée seminar. Playbook got a peek at the agenda, which includes climate, AI and migration.

Pitch, please: Cabinets have already sent in two-to-three-page SOTEU wish lists, while chiefs of staff had a lobbying opportunity during an away day last Friday. One EU official said Tervuren is less about throwing new ideas at von der Leyen than giving an extra push to existing ones.

Written in pen: Migration and wildfires practically pitch themselves. But China is climbing the agenda, two officials said. One section of the speech will remain "in square brackets" until almost the last moment, an official said — reserved for whatever geopolitical crisis demands von der Leyen's attention.

And then? "Straight to the 16th," a second official said. Meaning that after Tervuren, the lobbying window for commissioners and their cabinets is about to slam shut.

Unless you know Bjoern: There's always the bilateral route. As one Commission official bluntly put it: "The president is Bjoern," referring to Bjoern Seibert, von der Leyen's all-powerful chief of staff. If a pet project hasn't made the cut after tomorrow, cabinets need to go to the Berlaymont's 13th floor and seek him out.

Parliament's turn: Then come the European Parliament group leaders, who will sit down with von der Leyen at the Conference of Presidents on Sept. 9 — a traditional pre-SOTEU stop, Parliament officials told Max Grier.

Pitches for lunch: Last come the capitals. Von der Leyen will hold the traditional pre-SOTEU lunch with EU ambassadors on Sept. 11, one EU official and two diplomats confirmed.

Spoiler alert ... there'll be no spoilers. The speech will remain tightly under wraps during this meeting as well, though von der Leyen may offer a few hints on themes that have already done the rounds — such as competitiveness, one diplomat said.

The commissioners will get the text the evening before the speech — and cabinet members won't get it in advance. Even then, it may not be finished. Last time, politically explosive bits such as Israeli

sanctions were still being added at the 11th hour, a third official said.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Germany blamed Russia for the recent drone incursion in Leipzig and said it will propose new EU sanctions ... but how do EU sanctions get approved? First comes a proposal from either the Commission, the EEAS or member countries, which is then discussed by relevant bodies in the Council (that could be working parties and/or the Political and Security Committee), before the legal act needed to make the sanctions work is signed off by ambassadors. Every EU country needs to approve sanctions.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked who you think should be on the “council of elders” to steer EEAS reform. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

TAXING TIMES IN DUBLIN

RED LINES EMERGE: EU countries are starting to show their hands in negotiations over the bloc’s next long-term budget, Ireland’s Europe Affairs Minister Thomas Byrne told Zoya Sheftalovich, reporting alongside Gregorio Sorigi.

Out with it: “We are now beginning to hear from member states as to where their actual red lines are,” Byrne said after a week of tête-à-têtes with national counterparts.

Getting stuck in: Ministers are descending on Dublin today to thrash out changes to the European Commission’s near-€2 trillion proposal, including how to divide money among agriculture, regional development, competitiveness and defense. They need a deal by December to give lawmakers time to approve the package before it takes effect in 2028.

Size matters: Some governments want to shrink the proposal, while others say Europe’s new priorities require more money. “Volume is one of the issues that all of the member states have, whether it’s higher or lower,” Byrne said.

A taxing question: Diplomats have pointed to new EU-wide taxes as one way of squaring the circle, and the Irish presidency is expected to propose a new package of potential levies in October. The taxes frequently came up in talks with ministers, Byrne said.

Your choice: European Council President António Costa warned yesterday that failure to agree on new taxes would mean either higher national contributions or less ambition from Brussels.

Next move: Byrne said he hopes to propose a revised budget breakdown in late September or early October, and that he is confident governments can strike a deal before year-end.

DASHBOARD

Who rules the EU? Germany! That’s according to a poll conducted by Public First for POLITICO across six countries, Hanne Cokelaere writes. Just 22 percent of French respondents and around one-third of respondents in Spain and Germany said the EU institutions ensure that member countries have an equal voice. When asked which, if any, country holds the most sway, relative majorities in those three countries gave the same answer: Germany.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

CEUTA GETS WORSE: Pedro Sánchez faces a hostile session on the migration crisis in the Spanish parliament today, with lawmakers seizing on a report alleging Moroccan involvement in the sudden arrival of some 72,000 migrants in late July.

SKIP THE SPACE SUMMIT: The White House told American companies that attending Emmanuel Macron's space summit in Paris next week could look like they're tacitly supporting EU positions, my stateside colleagues scooped .

BARDELLA GOES GLOBAL: France's National Rally is deploying Jordan Bardella abroad to reassure markets that Marine Le Pen's party can be trusted with the economy.

TUSK BLAMES MOSCOW: Polish PM Donald Tusk said the fire at a Polish drone factory supplying weapons to Ukraine on Monday was "deliberate arson" and that Russia was likely behind it, Daria Zakharova reports.

NO IMMUNITY, THANKS: Slovenia's Robert Golob voted with every other lawmaker in the country's parliament yesterday to strip himself of immunity , clearing the way for a criminal case over alleged police meddling.

ACCELERATING SUPPORT: Industries are rallying behind the Industrial Accelerator Act as a surge in Chinese imports threatens to devastate European businesses.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy with a chance of rain. High of 24C.

FORGET COSTA'S CAPITALS TOUR ... European Economic and Social Committee President Séamus Boland has a more pastoral approach to EU diplomacy: inviting commissioners to his family farm in Ireland. Marta Kos is the latest visitor to the 130-year-old farm now run by Boland's son, Jamie; Jessika Roswall visited in July.

OUR ROBOT OVERLORDS: German EPP MEP Axel Voss organized a robot showcase in the European Parliament this week, which means prototypes from universities across the continent are roaming the corridors. There are dog-like robots, tap-dancing robots, and even humanoid robots loading dishwashers and displaying signs saying "we serve society." Some of these may have been actual MEPs (it's hard to tell).

ONE FOR THE MAYBE PILE? Ursula von der Leyen belongs to the German CDU, but is she a fan of the CD? We'll find out. Non-attached MEP Fernand Kartheiser is seeking backing for his call to get CD players back in new cars rather than having to rely on Spotify or other streaming services, Max Grier reports.

"The transition towards fully digital in-car entertainment raises important questions not only about consumer choice and cultural diversity, but also about accessibility and road safety," Kartheiser, a 66-year-old from Luxembourg, wrote in a parliamentary question sent out to all MEPs to get signatures before it's sent to the Commission. Maybe von der Leyen agrees and will make her SOTEU entrance to

“Video Killed the Radio Star.”

JOBBS CORNER: With the rentrée underway, a new wave of job moves is sweeping through Brussels’ diplomatic circles:

PSC pals: Anna Olsson Vrang joins the Swedish perm rep as ambassador to the Political and Security Committee ... and Conrad Hässler takes over in the same role for Germany.

Top diplos: The Danish embassy welcomes Camilla Saugstrup as its new Antici (the ambassadorial aides in Coreper II) and Clara Cilius Rødgaard as Mertens (the advisers in Coreper I). Janja Jenc becomes Slovenia’s Antici. Over in the French perm rep, Victor Xiberras becomes deputy Antici to work on enlargement.

HITTING THE HIGH NOTES: With cloudy and wet weather on the way, the days of outdoor bars and roof terraces will soon be over. But there’s a slew of concerts and musical events in the calendar over the coming weeks, offering everything from dream pop to didgeridoos for those wanting to stay dry.

— Emmylou Harris at Bozar tonight. The 79-year-old, multi-award-winning American country artist appears as part of her European Farewell Tour. Tickets are sold out but you could always chance your luck on a resale.

— Bedouin at Ancienne Belgique tomorrow night. Described as “dreamy folk music that gently settles in and leaves a deep impression,” for fans of Laura Marling and Aldous Harding. Tickets go for €22.

— Rachel Chinouriri’s “Botanique” gig on Sept. 10, where you’ll find your Playbook author. The new British indie star released one of 2025’s best albums — and this could be one of your last chances to catch her in such an intimate venue before she definitively blows up.

— Marni Jazz Festival at Theatre Marni, Sept. 10-19. This annual musical extravaganza features six concerts, ranging from Hungarian singers to jazz-pop.

— Solomun at the Palace of Justice on Sept. 19. For House music fans, the Bosnian-German DJ will be performing an open air concert at the iconic Brussels location organized by Hangar . A VIP event co-hosted by The Merode will follow the set.

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TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Saxony-Anhalt premier Sven Schulze may need The Left’s support to stay in power after Sunday’s election — but there’s fierce resistance among his own Christian Democrats to governing with the far left.

Paris: France’s political class is bracing for an economic crisis that could reshape next year’s presidential race.

London: Andy Burnham will press Emmanuel Macron to help curb irregular migration when he hosts the French president today — the first visit by a foreign leader to No. 10 since Burnham became PM.

Washington: Some Democrats are betting they can win back Latino voters by rooting their campaigns in local communities.

Canberra: Australia wanted to hold a climate showcase in the Pacific in the run-up to COP, but it's struggling to get world leaders to show up.

AGENDA

— European Council President António Costa continues his “Tour des Capitales,” meeting Romanian President Nicușor Dan in Bucharest; Bulgarian Prime Minister Rumen Radev in Sofia; and Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis in Athens.

— Informal meeting of the General Affairs Council in Dublin. Watch .

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Faroe Islands Foreign Affairs Minister Bárður á Steig Nielsen.

— Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera receives Polish Secretary of State for Strategic Energy Infrastructure Wojciech Wrochna.

— Innovation Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva meets Czech First Deputy Prime Minister and Industry and Trade Minister Karel Havlíček and Finance Minister Alena Schillerová.

— Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque receives European Chief Prosecutor Laura Kövesi.

— Internal Affairs Commissioner Magnus Brunner receives members of the German Bundestag.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall meets Irish Forestry Minister Niall Collins and Climate Minister Darragh O'Brien.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Inese Vaidere; former MEPs Peter van Dalen, Salvatore Cicu, Péter Niedermüller, Marc Joulaud and Arndt Kohn; the FT's Barbara Moens; former ECB president and Italian Prime Minister Mario Draghi; APRE's Mattia Ceracchi; L'Oréal's Annalisa Barbagallo.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from AMD:** Europe is in a decisive phase in the race to shape its AI future. Building infrastructure that will reinforce long-term autonomy, resilience and competitiveness is an imperative. Choices made now influence who retains leverage, how quickly Europe can respond to change and where the value created by AI ultimately resides. Systems built on open standards and interoperability give institutions, researchers and enterprises the freedom to adapt, integrate new capabilities and avoid dependence on any single technology path. Supplier diversity strengthens that equation by reducing concentration risk and supporting a more resilient innovation ecosystem. A competitive AI ecosystem depends on an open technology stack that enables choice across hardware, software and deployment

models.**

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